



TOMORROW

By **S. PRASANNARAJAN**

Crystal ball gazers of geopolitics and prophets of national destiny keep telling us the good news: Indian Awakening is the next big global bang. An Indian Century? Why not, especially since the *fin* of the American *siècle* is playing out its last act in the barren remoteness of Mesopotamia and Afghanistan? And since the twin giants of the East—Beijing and New Delhi—are shifting the traditional pendulum of power. It does indeed warm the national heart to hear that the future is fabulous, particularly so as this is a country that never ceases to astonish us with its volume and volatility, its elasticity and eclecticism. We have come so

far, scarred but not defeated, and we have outlived the maddest provocations of the political class, ranging from their socialist fantasies to totalitarian temptations. Today, India is no longer the proverbial third world idealist with a closed mind. It's one of the most spirited democracies at work, though the plurality of our politics is only matched by its vulgarity. The Indian marketplace is still expanding, possibly even struggling to keep pace with the aspirations of its entrepreneurs. It is not only the resilience of the economy that raises a national cheer. Biologically too, we can afford to be a bit boastful: India is growing younger, though the grey eminences in power are still our highest arbiters. Well, balladeers of the Orient have a new song to sing, and it's not necessarily about the majesty of Cathay.

The Great Tomorrow is a heady sensation, and it inclines us to be less realistic about the present. That is why, before we pop the cork, we need to come to terms with the distance between our global ambitions and domestic attitudes. The expansiveness of our democracy has not always

resulted in a robust sense of the nation. A hundred ideas of India are at work today, and some versions are as small—and provincial—as the mind of their political votaries. India may be more visible—and audible—at international high tables, and it is certainly a reflection of the confidence with which we engage the world. Back home, though, we don't have a coherent argument on national security, in spite of being consistently reminded that we are a frontline victim of terror. Short-term political expediency is not what a nation with great-power pretensions expects from its leadership. Also remember, in the so called flat world, it's easy to get carried away by the digital metaphor of Bangalore. Beyond the glitz of the bazaar, there are disquieting sites of dispossession; they may delight the pornographers of poverty but they should shame those who swear by the politics of social justice. Sixty two years ago, "Tomorrow" was the mid-night dream of a free people. Today the sweep of our dream is a measure of our freedom. So listen to the many variations of our future in the rustle of the following pages. ■

